

1982–83 Yuri Andropov becomes Soviet president. His anticorruption purge results in the emergence of a new generation of Central Asian officials.

1989 First non-communist political movement, Unity Party (Birlik), is formed but not officially recognized. A Birlik campaign leads to Uzbek being declared the official language.

1990 Islam Karimov becomes executive president of the new Uzbek Supreme Soviet. Inter-ethnic fighting in the Fergana Valley causes 320 deaths.

1991 As the USSR collapses, Uzbekistan declares its independence and adopts the Republic of Uzbekistan as its official name. Uzbekistan joins the Commonwealth of Independent States (CIS). The Communist Party of Uzbekistan is restructured as the People's Democratic Party of Uzbekistan (PDP) with Islam Karimov confirmed as president.

1992 Price liberalization provokes student riots in Tashkent. A new post-Soviet constitution is adopted along Western democratic lines, but all religious and nationalist parties are banned. Uzbekistan sends troops to Tajikistan to suppress violence and strengthen border.

1993 Growing harassment of opposition political parties, the nationalist Erk (Freedom) and religious Birlik (Unity).

1995 Karimov's PDP wins legislative elections. Referendum extends Karimov's presidential term until 2000.

1996 Islamic Movement of Uzbekistan (IMU) formed to fight for Islamic republic.

1999 Bomb attacks by IMU lead to crackdown and arrests of hundreds of opposition activists.

2000 Karimov is reelected as president in elections widely viewed as rigged.

2001 US sets up up an air base at Khanabad to help it fight the Taliban in Afghanistan, but its aid to Uzbekistan is stopped in 2004 because of human rights abuses. The Uzbek government closes the base in 2005.

2002 Presidential term extended from five to seven years.

2005 Government troops shoot about 750 unarmed people in Andijan in the Fergana Valley demonstrating in support of 23 local people charged with "extremism," that is, membership of a banned Islamic organization.

2007 President Karimov is elected for new seven-year term in disputed election.

2008 Uzbekistan announces it is to allow US forces to use the Termez air base, following their expulsion from the base at Khanabad in 2005.

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Turkmenistan



A poor and isolated Central Asian nation with a long history of despotic rule.

1229 Genghis Khan conquers the region.

1600s The territory, occupied by Turkmen tribes, is fought over by Persia, the khanates of Khiva and Bukhara, and Afghanistan.

1881 Russian forces, led by General Skobelev, conquer Turkmen stronghold of Gok-Teppeh, killing over 14,000 people. Ashgabat is founded by the Russians in the Akhal-Teke oasis. It becomes first a military stronghold, then a trading center.

1884 The oasis city of Merv is conquered by Russia. The invasion, which takes Russian forces to the borders of Afghanistan and Persia by 1900, results in Turkmen tribes fleeing to Persia.

1918–19 After the Russian Revolution, an independent Turkmen administration is supported by a British garrison.

1920 Bolsheviks capture Turkmen territory.

1921 Turkestan is reconstituted as an Autonomous Soviet Socialist Republic with the Russian Soviet Federative Socialist Republic (RSFSR).

1924 Creation of Turkmen Soviet Socialist Republic.

1948 Earthquake rocks Ashgabat, killing 100,000.

1985 Saparmurad Niyazov becomes president of the Communist Party.

1990 Niyazov is elected president of the Turkmenistan SSR.

1991 Independence from USSR: Niyazov becomes president of new state, bans Communist Party and forms the Democratic Party of Turkmenistan, the country's only legal party.

1992 Niyazov is reelected unopposed as president.

1994 After parliament votes to extend Niyazov's term of office to 2002, a referendum shows that 99.99 percent of voters are in favor.

1995 Turkmenistan's declaration of neutrality is recognized by the UN.

1999 Niyazov's term of office is extended indefinitely by parliament.

2000 All government officials forced to speak Turkmen as other native languages are banned from public use.

2002 Niyazov revises the calendar, naming months after himself, his mother, and *Ruhnama*, his spiritual guidebook.

TURKMEN LEADER (1940–2006)

SAPARMURAD NIYAZOV

Saparmurad Niyazov styled himself Turkmenbashi, the "father of all Turkmen." In power from 1990 to his death in 2006, he fostered an extreme personality cult in his country and enacted a number of highly eccentric laws. His portrait adorns buildings, while towns, streets, and even months of the year have been renamed in his honor. His spiritual guide to living, *Ruhnama*, was adopted as the national guidebook to be studied by all students. Most dramatically, a giant gold statue of him stands in the center of the capital, Ashgabat, revolving every 24 hours so that the Sun always shines on his face.



2002 Opposition parties in exile form Turkmen Democratic Opposition in Vienna. A coup attempt later in the year is blamed on the group, leading to mass repression and imprisonment of opponents.

2003 The government removes the right of Russians—who form 10 percent of the population—to hold dual citizenship, and gives them two months to decide which passport to keep.

2006 Human rights activist Ogulsapar Muradova dies in prison. Niyazov dies of a heart attack.

2007 Gurbanguli Berdimukhamedov, former health minister and deputy prime minister, is elected president with 89 percent of the vote.

2008 A new constitution establishes a directly elected parliament. The Gregorian calendar is readopted.

2009 Gas pipeline opens to China.

2010 The gold statue of former president Niyazov is removed from Ashgabat.

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Kyrgyzstan



A small, mountainous state with a largely rural population and a large Russian minority.

700s Kyrgyz people begin to settle and trade in the valley of the Chu River, site of the present-day capital Bishkek.

1855 Borombei Bekmurotov, chief of the nomad Bugu tribe east of Issyk Kul, accepts dependence on the Russian Empire.

1876 Kyrgyz lands annexed into the Russian Empire.

1924 Incorporated into the USSR.

1991 Independence from USSR under President Askar Akayev.

2005 Akayev swept aside in the Tulip Revolution after he attempts to rig presidential elections. Kurmanbek Bakiyev elected president.

2006 President Bakiyev establishes a new constitution limiting his powers.

2007 The opposition fails to win a single seat in elections amid fraud allegations.

2009 President Bakiyev announces closure of the US air base at Manas.

2009 Bakiyev swept from power. Roza Otunbayeva becomes president.

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Tajikistan



A mountainous state whose languages and traditions are similar to those of Iran.

1876 Russians conquer the region.

1924 Soviets take over Tajikistan.

1929 Tajikistan becomes a full republic of the USSR as Tajik SSR.

1940 Cyrillic script is introduced.

1989 Tajik becomes official language.

1991 Independence from USSR; the previous communist leader, Rakhmon Nabiev, wins elections.

1992 Demonstrators force Nabiev from power. Civil war breaks out as Islamic Revival Party fights for an Islamic republic. Another former communist, Imomali Rakhmonov, wins power.

1997–98 Peace accord with rebels as Islamists join government.

2006 Rakhmonov wins reelection in an election considered corrupt by foreign observers. (Reelected 2010.)

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